

Presentation Skills

- "Public speaking is not a talent - it is a skill." — *Unknown*
- "There is no such thing as presentation talent, it is called Presentation Skills" — *David JP Phillips*
- "A wise man speaks because he has something to say, a fool speaks because he has to say something." — *Plato*
- "There are always three speeches, for every one you actually gave. The one you practiced, the one you gave, and the one you wish you gave." — *Dale Carnegie*

Facts

19 FASCINATING STATISTICS THAT MAKE THE CASE FOR USING VISUAL CONTENT

1. 90% of information transmitted to the brain is visual, and visuals are processed 60,000X faster in the brain than text.
2. 40% of people will respond better to visual information than plain text.
3. 46.1% of people say a website's design is the number one criterion for discerning the credibility of the company.
4. Visual content drives engagement. In fact, just one month after the introduction of Facebook time line of brands, visual content – photos and videos – saw a 65% increase in engagement.
5. On Facebook, photos perform best for likes, comments, and shares as compared to text, video, and links.
6. 37% of P interest account holders log in a few times every week; 28% said they log in a few times a month; 15% log in once daily; 10% log in numerous times a day.
7. 85% of the US internet audience watches videos online. The 25-34 age group watches the most online videos, and adult males spend 40% more time watching videos on

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- the internet than females.
- 8. Over 60 hours of videos are uploaded each minute on YouTube.com.
- 9. 700 YouTube videos are shared on Twitter every minute.
- 10. Viewers spend 100% more time on pages with videos on them.
- 11. Mobile video viewing increased 35% from 2010 to 2011.
- 12. 25 million Smartphone users stream 4 hours of mobile video per month. 75% of smartphone users watch videos on their phones, 26% of whom uses video at least once a day.
- 13. Mobile video subscription is expected to hit \$16 billion in revenue by 2014, with over 500 million subscribers.

Everyone has a preferred learning style, but most people respond better to visuals than with the spoken word alone. Consider the following research findings:

- 1. People gain 75% of what they know visually, 13% through hearing, and 12% through smell.
- 2. A picture is three times more effective in conveying information than words alone.
- 3. Words and pictures together are six times more effective than words alone.

It is said that "Half the world is composed of people who have something to say and they cannot say and the other half, who have nothing to say and they keep on saying it". The ability to make effective and memorable oral presentations is one the most important qualities you need to develop for a successful career. And constant practice would help you acquire this skill.

The more successful your career, the more often you will be called upon to make presentations for a variety of situations and audiences.

9.1. MEANING

The formal presentation of information is divided into two broad categories:

- 1. Presentation Skills and
- 2. Personal Presentation.

These two aspects are interwoven and can be described as the preparation, presentation and practice of verbal and non-verbal communication.

Many people feel terrified when asked to make their first public talk. Some of these initial fears can be reduced by good preparation that also lays the groundwork for making an effective presentation.

A Presentation is...

A presentation is a means of communication that can be adapted to various speaking situations, such as talking to a group, addressing a meeting or briefing a team.

A presentation can also be used as a broad term that encompasses other 'speaking engagements' such as making a speech at a wedding, or getting a point across in a video conference.

To be effective, step-by-step preparation and the method and means of presenting the information should be carefully considered.

9.2. TYPES OF PRESENTATIONS AND PURPOSE

There are five different types of presentations you can give and their purpose is to invoke different reactions. The first step in preparing a presentation is to define the purpose of your presentation. The following is an overview of several common types of presentations and their purpose. Each presentation type requires a specific organization technique to assure they are understood and remembered by the audience. The suggested **organizational structure** is also provided.

1. Informative
2. Instructional
3. Arousing
4. Persuasive
5. Decision-making
6. Presentations that Entertain

1. Informative

Keep an informative presentation brief and to the point. Stick to the facts and avoid complicated information. Choose one of the following organizational structures for an informative presentation:

(a) Time

- (i) Explains when things should happen.
- (ii) Works best with visual people or people who can see the overall organization or sequence of events.
- (iii) Use words like "first," "second," "third," to list order.

(b) Place

- (i) Explains where things should happen.
- (ii) Works best with people who understand the group or area you are talking about.
- (iii) Use words like "Region 1, 2, 3, or 4" to explain order.

(c) Cause and Effect

- (i) Explains how things should happen.
- (ii) Works best with people who understand the relationship between events.
- (iii) Use phrases like "Because of _____, we now have to _____".

(d) Logical Order. Simply list items in their order of importance

Works best with people who are accustomed to breaking down complex data into components in order to digest the material.

2. Instructional

Your purpose in an instructional presentation is to give specific directions or orders. Your

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presentation will probably be a bit longer, because it has to cover your topic thoroughly. In an instructional presentation, your listeners should come away with new knowledge or a new skill.

- (a) Explain why the information or skill is valuable to the audience.
- (b) Explain the learning objectives of the instructional program.
- (c) Demonstrate the process if it involves something in which the audience will later participate using the following method
 - (i) Demonstrate it first without comment.
 - (ii) Demonstrate it again with a brief explanation.
 - (iii) Demonstrate it a third time, step-by-step, with an explanation.
 - (iv) Have the participants practice the skill.
- (d) Provide participants the opportunity to ask questions, give, and receive feedback from you and their peers.
- (e) Connect the learning to actual use.
- (f) Have participants verbally state how they will use it.

3. Arousing

Your purpose in an arousing presentation is to make people think about a certain problem or situation. You want to arouse the audience's emotions and intellect so that they will be receptive to your point of view. Use vivid language in an arousing presentation – project sincerity and enthusiasm.

- (a) Gain attention with a story that illustrates (and sometimes exaggerates) the problem.
- (b) Show the need to solve the problem and illustrate it with an example that is the general or common place.
- (c) Describe your solution for a satisfactory resolution to the problem.
- (d) Compare/contrast the two worlds with the problem solved and unsolved.
- (e) Call the audience to action to help solve the problem.
- (f) Give the audience a directive that is clear, easy, and immediate.

4. Persuasive

Your purpose in a persuasive presentation is to convince your listeners to accept your proposal. A convincing, persuasive presentation offers a solution to a controversy, dispute, or problem. To succeed with a persuasive presentation, you must present sufficient logic, evidence, and emotion to sway the audience to your viewpoint.

- (a) Create a great introduction because a persuasive presentation introduction must accomplish the following:
 - (i) Seize the audience's attention.
 - (ii) Disclose the problem or needs that your product or service will satisfy.

- (b) Tantalize the audience by describing the advantages of solving the problem or need.
- (c) Create a desire for the audience to agree with you by describing exactly how your product or service to fill their real needs.
- (d) Close your persuasive presentation with a call to action.
- (e) Ask for the order.
- (f) Ask for the decision that you want to be made.
- (g) Ask for the course of action that you want to be followed.

5. Decision-making

Your purpose in a decision-making presentation is to move your audience to take your suggested action. A decision-making presentation presents ideas, suggestions, and arguments strongly enough to persuade an audience to carry out your requests. In a decision-making presentation, you must tell the audiences what to do and how to do it. You should also let them know what will happen if they don't do what you ask.

1. Gain attention with a story that illustrates the problem.
2. Show the need to solve the problem and illustrate it with an example that is general or commonplace.
3. Describe your solution to bring a satisfactory resolution to the problem.
4. Compare/contrast the two worlds with the problem solved and unsolved.

Call the audience to action to help solve the problem and give them a way to be part of the solution.

6. Presentations that Entertain

Speaking for the sole purposes of entertaining is not usually appropriate in business. Whether your purpose in speaking is to inform or persuade, however, a little "comic relief" almost always makes a presentation more enjoyable and therefore more effective.

Stories and jokes can help make the listener's job easier. Humor is tricky, however. Not everyone can tell the same joke with the same success, and some people feel foolish telling stories. You will need to discover for yourself what works best for you, using the following hints as a starting point:

1. **Stories and jokes can be effective icebreakers.** When you begin your presentation with a story or joke, both you and your audience have a chance to relax and become comfortable before the actual message begins. Unless you are comfortable with telling jokes or stories, however, you will do well to avoid them and find another way to break the ice. The way the audience responds to your opening remarks will influence their response to your entire presentation.

2. **Make sure that your material is current.** Unless you can provide a new twist, an old joke is worse than no joke at all. It does not help to ask your audience to stop you if they have heard it before—even if they have heard it, they will not stop you, but will let you tell it and then not respond, leaving you hanging. Use material that's both current and appropriate for your presentation.
3. **Keep the entertainment material related to but separate from your main message.** Remember that any entertainment material is primarily filler, to be used to influence the mood of the audience. The point of your stories and jokes should relate to the topic of your presentation so that your transitions from the stories and jokes to the main points of your presentation can be clear. The emphasis belongs on your main points.
4. **Keep the material in good taste.** In addition to avoiding ethnic and sexist humor, be aware of the sensitivities of the group. Stories and jokes that center on sex, politics, and religion are almost guaranteed to offend someone in a large group and are usually best avoided. If you have any doubt about whether a group is “ready” for a particular joke or story, avoid using it.

9.2.1. The Audience

“Make sure you have finished speaking before your audience has finished listening.”

— Dorothy Sarnoff

The audience is an important variable in any communication situation; as a rule, however, analyzing an audience for an oral presentation is easier than analyzing an audience for a written message. You and your audience are in the same place at the same time, usually for a specific purpose.

You also usually have some information about your audience's other interests, as well as their range in ages, educational backgrounds, and occupations. Based on your analysis of that information, you should be able to make some predictions about how the audience will receive you and your message.

The attributes of your audience that will have the greatest influence on your presentation are size, attitude toward you and your subject, and their previous knowledge about the subject.

1. Audience Size. The size of the audience is an important influence on any presentation. In general, the larger the group, the more difficult it is to satisfy everyone. Sometimes, just gaining the attention of a large group can be a challenge. The three most important qualities of large audiences that cause problems for presenters are the following:

- (a) The members of a large group are less cohesive—less willing to stick together—than members of a smaller group. The behavior of large audiences is less predictable than that of small groups.
- (b) The members of a large group are likely to have less in common with one another than members of a small group. In any large group, some members of the audience will disagree with you.

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(c) The members of a large group have a greater variation in attitudes, knowledge about the subject, and educational level than members of a smaller group. Large groups present greater challenges for finding the appropriate balance of technical and nontechnical information.

2. **Audience Attitude.** The attitude of the audience toward you and your subject can vary in several ways. The audience may

- (a) Like you and like your subject.
- (b) Like you but dislike your subject.
- (c) Dislike you but like your subject.
- (d) Dislike both you and your subject.
- (e) Like or dislike you and be neutral about your subject.
- (f) Be neutral about you and like or dislike your subject.
- (g) Be neutral about you and your subject.

3. **Audience Knowledge.** What does your audience already know about your subject? What is the typical educational level of those in the audience? The answers to these questions determine what you will need to do to adapt your presentation to fit a specific audience. When the audience is unfamiliar with the subject, or when the subject is complex given their educational background, you will need to make a special effort to help your audience understand:

- (a) Use a vocabulary that everyone will understand.
- (b) Explain technical terms.
- (c) Make your organizational plan obvious, and make transitions clear.
- (d) Repeat and emphasize key points.

9.3. TECHNIQUES OF PRESENTATION SKILLS

Regardless of the variables in the situation, the techniques required for an effective presentation are essentially the same. You will need to plan what you will say, establish credibility, deliver the message, and obtain feedback.

"Words have incredible power.
They can make people's hearts soar,
or they can make people's hearts sore."

— Dr. Mardy Grothe

9.3.1. Planning

How much planning you must do before you speak depends on the complexity of the subject and the formality of the situation. Complex subjects require more planning than simple ones, and formal situations give you less margin for error than informal situations.

1. **Know Your Subject.** People are usually asked to speak about things they know. Other than impromptu speeches, however, presentations will require at least some specific preparation to adapt material to the audience and occasion and to ensure that the most important points are covered in a logical order. Being thoroughly familiar with your subject and what you intend to say.
2. **Be Positive.** In previous times, military commanders who did not want to hear that the battle had been lost often put bearers of bad news to death. This is the origin of the expression, killing the messenger. Although there may be times you have no choice but to deliver bad news, people tend to associate those who present negative messages with the bad news. For this reason, when possible, avoid saying negative things about people, organizations, or ideas presented by others. Another reason to focus on the positive is that people process positive language more quickly and easily than they do negative language.
3. **Rehearse.** How much time you should spend rehearsing what you want to say depends on the importance of and complexity of the situation. Some complex situations may require months of research, preparation, and rehearsing. Rehearsing can be tricky, however. You should rehearse enough to be familiar and comfortable with your message, but not so much that your delivery is stiff and tired. To be effective as a presenter, you must know what you want to say well enough to say it without reading it or memorizing it.
4. **Be clear, truthful, and interesting.** You can't be perfect; nobody is. You cannot prepare for every contingency; and you cannot know everything about your subject, the circumstances, or the audience. You do, however, owe it to your audience to present what you do know in a clear, truthful, and interesting way, and that's all they will expect.

9.3.2. Establishing Credibility

Your credibility as a message source will have an important influence on the reception the audience gives your message. You can establish long-term credibility only by becoming a recognized expert in a given area. Once you have established yourself as an authority, you carry this credibility with you into new situations calling for your expertise. Long-term credibility in one area has a halo effect or carry-over credibility that increases the perception of your credibility in other areas as well.

Even if you possess long-term credibility, you will still need to establish short-term credibility with your audience each time you speak. To help ensure high short-term credibility, make clear distinctions among facts, inferences, and value judgments (opinions) and by telling your audience how you know what the facts are.

9.3.3. Delivering the Message

In addition to the structure and content of your message, the way you deliver it will also have an influence on its reception. Whatever the size of your audience, the skills you need to make an effective presentation are essentially the same as the conversational skills you have been using all your life. Anything that makes your communication effective in one-on-one situations will

also make it effective with larger groups.

Unfortunately, the larger the size of the audience, the easier it is to forget the basic conversational skills. Most people find large audiences at least a little intimidating. The fundamental rules for delivering a message to a group are the following:

1. **Relax.** One of the things effective presenters have in common is that they are relaxed and comfortable while speaking to a group. If you appear nervous and uncomfortable, your audience will become nervous and uncomfortable as well.

Use natural gestures and movements, but avoid pacing and other rhythmic movements and nervous mannerisms.

2. **Involve everyone.** Whatever the size of the group, take a moment before you begin to speak to establish eye contact with as many people as possible. Make sure that everyone can hear you. When people have a problem hearing a speaker, they will tune out rather than struggle to hear. If the group is large, use a sound system.

3. **Be enthusiastic.** If you are interested in and enthusiastic about your subject, you increase the level of interest and enthusiasm in your audience. Your voice and your physiology should indicate your level of enthusiasm. If you say, for example, that you are "glad to be here," your voice and your body should show that you truly are glad. If you look depressed and speak in a small, shaky voice, your audience will believe your appearance rather than your words.

Even when you must convey bad news, your audience will appreciate it if you seem confident that you and your organization are doing everything possible to ensure the best possible outcome for everyone involved.

4. **Stick to the subject.** Entertainment material is useful only if it helps you convey your message. Jokes, stories, and other material inserted for entertainment purposes must be related to your message closely enough to ensure that the audience can see the connection. Remember that you have a purpose in speaking and that your principal objective is to accomplish that purpose.

9.3.4. Obtaining Feedback

You need to obtain feedback from your audience for two distinct reasons. First, you need feedback to make sure that your audience is hearing and understanding your message. Second, you need feedback to help you do a better job on your next presentation.

To ensure that everyone is hearing and understanding you, maintain eye contact with your audience and invite questions.

1. **Use eye contact.** The only way to know how the members of your audience are responding to you is to look at them.

2. **Invite questions.** Let your audience know in advance whether you prefer to receive questions at the end of the presentation or as you go along. Some speakers think that in formal situations, questions should be held until the end-or at least until the end of logical units.

When someone has a question, others probably have the same question, which suggests a need for clarification. If a question anticipates a point that you will be addressing later in the presentation, you can ask the person to hold the question until that point by saying something like, "That's a good question, and I will be addressing that issue in a few minutes. I'd appreciate it if you'd ask your question at that time."

To obtain feedback for the second objective of doing a better job with your next presentation, do the following:

1. **Analyze the audience's questions.** Keep track of the questions the members of your audience ask, and then revise your presentation to ensure that you provide better coverage of the topics they asked about during your next presentation.
2. **Invite evaluation.** When it's appropriate for you to do so, request an evaluation of your presentation by your supervisor or a trusted colleague. In sales situations, you can often ask for and receive feedback from one or more of the people to whom you presented after they have made the decision about whether to buy from you.

Remember that the feedback does you no good unless you act on what you have learned. Not every comment you receive will be valid, but if four or five people tell you that you need to speak more slowly or more quickly, you would do well to change the pace of your delivery.

9.3.5. Preparation and Support

Formal presentations differ from other kinds of oral communication primarily because one person speaks for an extended time without receiving much oral feedback. In most other communication situations—from interviews to group meetings—the participants exchange a series of short messages and comment on what others have said. In a formal presentation, the speaker is expected to deliver a fully planned, well-organized, extended message on a topic usually announced in advance to the audience.

Restricted oral feedback is a criterion of a formal presentation. Sometimes the medium used for the presentation, as would be the case with a televised presentation, may make feedback virtually impossible. Other formal presentations may permit questions and answers during the presentation itself, but even in such cases, feedback is restricted to help ensure the orderly presentation of ideas.

Formality and Expectations. Planned presentation and restricted feedback are among the characteristics that make formal presentations formal. Contributing to the formality are the serious intent of both the presenter and the audience, the distance maintained between the speaker and the audience, and the fact that the presentation will take place at a specific time and place.

The degree of formality can vary greatly, however. The most formal kind of presentation, the reading of a paper, is rarely used in business. Presenters at academic conferences and scientific gatherings may read papers to ensure that complex information is conveyed accurately. To help ensure the accurate transfer of the information, members of the audience are typically given copies of the paper, either before or following the reading. (Also, most academics and scientists are not known for their presentation skills and reading the paper precludes certain kinds of problems with delivery.)

In business, the following kinds of presentations-listed in order of decreasing formality-are most common:

1. **Public speech or lecture.** Public presentations are prepared in advance and typically delivered with the aid of notes. Oral feedback is usually restricted to the end of the presentation, if any is permitted at all.
2. **Sales presentation.** Sales presentations may be invited or uninvited, with invited sales presentations being the more formal of the two. In an invited sales presentation, the speaker has been specifically invited to present his or her product or service to those who will make the purchasing decision. Most sales presentations include time for questions and answers, but because the decision-making group may elect not to ask questions, the sales presentation needs to be complete by itself.
3. **Education and training presentation.** Education and training presentations combine the characteristics of lectures and discussion sessions. The speaker must be fully prepared both to deliver a specific message and to deal with a wide range of questions about related subject matter. Oral feedback is encouraged during and after the presentation and, sometimes, even before it.
4. **Discussion sessions.** Because they permit the most interaction between the speaker (or speakers) and the audience, discussion sessions are the least formal of formal presentations. Even for these presentations, time, place, and topic are determined in advance, however, and the speakers must prepare an organized message.
5. **Informal oral reports.** A common occurrence in business is for managers to ask members of their staffs to report on their progress with a particular project or a solution to a problem. At any staff meeting, you may be called upon to brief your department or committee on something you have been working on. Although the situation is much less formal than most other presentation types, others will be judging you on the quality of your presentation, so be prepared.

Note that, in general, as the formality of the presentation decreases, the responsibility of the presenter also decreases, while the responsibility of the audience increases. In a public speech or lecture, the audience is characteristically responsible only for listening; whereas in discussion sessions and for most informal oral reports, the audience is expected to participate by asking questions and making comments.

9.3.6. Presentation Support

In formal presentations, the sender of the message is either trying to inform the audience or to persuade the audience to change an attitude, belief, or behavior. The presentation should be organized to meet its objective in the same way written messages are organized to meet their objectives. Because the message is delivered orally, however, the presenter needs to take additional precautions to help ensure that the audience receives and understands the message. Preparation is the key to success in attaining the objective of an oral presentation.

For most formal presentations, you will need two kinds of support: notes and visual aids, which typically depend on equipment of one type or another.

Notes. The kind of notes you will require will depend on the situation and your familiarity with the material. The audience will expect you to be sufficiently familiar with your topic that you can move from point to point without excessive reliance on notes, but they will expect you to need to check notes for certain specifics, such as the technical details of a complex product.

If you feel the need to have your complete text available, emphasize the outline (by using a large, bold font or highlighter). Know your material well enough that you can move about naturally, referring to the text only when you need to provide the audience with a specific detail or need to refresh your memory on a particular point. Your notes should give structure to your presentation and allow you sufficient flexibility to adapt to the needs and interests of a specific audience.

Paraphernalia. When a presentation contains complex information, speakers typically rely on communication aids to help an audience follow and understand the information being presented. The most common supplements to an oral presentation are chalk and white boards, display boards, flip charts, projectors, handouts, and models.

Chalk and White Boards. Whether black or green, chalkboards are the oldest and best known communication aids. Boards may be prepared in advance or used at any time to illustrate or emphasize a point. The basic rules for using chalk and white boards are the following:

1. **Write legibly.** Your writing should be big enough and dark enough for everyone in the room to read. Start at the left side of the board (as you are facing it), and work to the right.
2. **Keep the message simple.** Use chalk or markers of different colors to emphasize different aspects of a message.
3. **Stay out of the way, and speak to the group.** Make sure that the audience can see what you have written or drawn. Stand to one side when you are referring to information on the board, and use a pointer if one is available. Speak to the audience rather than to the board. One of the most common mistakes presenters make is turning their backs on the audience and then reading from a board or projector screen. Face your audience when you are speaking.
4. **Erase the board when finished.** When you have finished with the information on the board, erase it. Also, erasing the board before leaving the room has been known as the first rule of teaching because it is a courtesy to the next person who will use the room. Even in

the organizational setting, it's a good habit to have to help ensure the confidentiality of proprietary information.

Display Boards. Felt or magnetic display boards, or special displays are used primarily for sales presentations to small audiences. They are typically used to present photographs and other information that will remain constant throughout the presentation.

Flip Charts. A flip chart consists of a pad of paper (usually 28 × 34 inches) mounted on an easel. Like the chalkboard, a flip chart is inexpensive and can be used spontaneously. The main advantages of a flip chart are that they require no erasing and different color markers can be used to help create visual interest. Flip charts may also be prepared in advance.

Projectors. The most common projection device is the ubiquitous overhead projector. It is currently the standard device for visual support. Virtually every classroom and conference room has one. It is the one piece of equipment presenters can count on being available wherever they go. Other projector types include computer-based projection systems, opaque projectors, slide projectors, VCR and TV systems, and film projectors.

Handouts. Handouts are written supplements that a presenter is distributed to the audience. They can be anything from a single page of material for copies of books or magazines. Handouts have a wide variety of uses, including the following:

1. To provide details you don't have time to cover.
2. To illustrate specific points of your presentation.
3. To serve as worksheets for your audience.
4. To outline the key points of your presentation and thus help your audience follow your message more easily.
5. To provide a summary of your presentation.
6. To provide statistical data or other information that supports your generalizations.
7. To present information that is too complex to present with other special techniques.
8. To obtain the feedback you need to determine whether the audience understood your message or to help you do a better job with your next presentation.

When you use handouts, remember that too much information frequently has the same effect as too little. If you distribute too many handouts, your audience will not separate the important from the inconsequential—it will all be thrown out together. When you are distributing several items, color-code them to help your audience keep track. Avoid the temptation to read handout material; your audience can read the information for themselves.

Use the handouts to supplement your presentation, to provide illustrations, or to remind the audience of the presentation. Distribute handouts in advance only when the audience will need to use the materials as you make your presentation.

9.3.7. Delivery

"Don't sell what you don't believe in - we will see through it. If you don't believe in
— *Unknown*
your message don't attempt to sell it."

It should be obvious that to give an effective oral presentation, you need to know what you are talking about. The first step in delivering an effective preparation is to make sure that you are thoroughly familiar with your subject. Second, to the extent that it is possible to know such things in advance, you need to have a good understanding of your audience and the context in which you will be speaking.

9.3.8. Preparing

The three cornerstones of preparation are to know your material, know your audience, and know your objective. Knowing your material, however, does not mean that you should memorize what you are going to say. Memorized presentations sound stilted and awkward, and you risk having your memory fail. When that happens, you are left with nothing to say and nowhere to go. The best preparation is to know your material well enough to be able to speak from an outline.

Prepare yourself for the following :

1. **Enunciation.** Are you pronouncing all words clearly and distinctly? Check words you are unsure of the dictionary. Be especially careful with words ending in ing-doing sounds.
2. **Modulation.** Your voice should rise and fall in both volume and pitch naturally, increasing in volume to emphasize important points, and decreasing from time to time to provide variety.
3. **Paralanguage.** Paralanguage consists of all vocalized sounds other than words, including laughter, throat-clearing sounds, and such fillers as uh, um, and verbal tics (OK, you know). Make sure that you are speaking at a moderate rate, neither too fast nor too slow. Compare your rate of delivery to that of the best-known television newscasters. If you speak at about the same rate, others will find it easy to listen to you.
4. **Projection.** Does your voice carry well enough for you to be heard at the back of the room? If not, use a microphone. It is better to use a mike than to strain your voice.

9.3.9. Coping with Stage Fright

Virtually everyone is nervous about speaking in front of a group at least the first time. Fear of public speaking-stage fright-is the most common type of performance anxiety. Getting up in front of an audience the first few times is unpleasant for some, difficult for most, and nearly impossible for a few others.

Practice is the most reliable cure for stage fright. The first presentation is the hardest; each subsequent time will get a bit easier. You will, of course, need to rehearse for all your important presentations, but practice is especially important before your first professional presentation.

Use your imagination to picture yourself in front of your audience, speaking and moving naturally. As you gain experience speaking to groups, you will need to spend less time on rehearsal of this variety.

While you are rehearsing your presentation, keep the following points in mind:

1. You were asked to make the presentation because you know something about the subject that the audience does not. Focus on that aspect of the subject, and give the audience something that will benefit them.
2. Your subject and your audience are more important than you are. Think about your audience and your subject rather than about yourself.
3. No presentation is perfect. You are bound to make a mistake or two-everyone does. If you make a mistake, you can correct yourself and move on. Keep going forward rather than looking back.
4. You cannot please all the people all the time. No matter how well (or poorly) you actually perform, someone in the audience will think you were wonderful, and somebody will think you were awful. Do not let the one who thinks you were wonderful blind you to your mistakes or let the one who thinks you were awful undermine your confidence.

9.3.10. Delivering the Message

When the day and time of your presentation arrives, arrive sufficiently early to check the room and equipment-or to set up, if you have that responsibility as well. In particular, check the following:

1. **The room arrangement.** Are the chairs for the audience arranged appropriately for your presentation? Will those seated in the back be able to hear you and see you and your visual aids?
2. **The lighting.** Will you need to adjust the lighting in the room (either by opening or closing curtains or by adjusting the lights)? If the lighting will require adjustment during your presentation, do you know how to do that, or will someone be available who can help?
3. **The sound system.** If your audience will be large enough so that you will need a sound system, check to make sure that it works. If you have a choice of microphone, request a lavalier. A lavalier mike will allow you to move around while speaking. A hand-held mike is second best because it limits your gestures and needs to be held at a fairly constant distance from your mouth so that your voice hits the "sweet spot" on the mike that allows for the cleanest sound. Because a stationary microphone attached to a lectern increases the physical and psychological separation between speaker and audience, consider them a last resort to be used only for speaking to large audiences when you have no other options.
4. **Audiovisual equipment.** What kind of audiovisual support will be appropriate for your presentation? Is the equipment there, and does it work properly? Computer-based projection systems in particular require additional time to set up, so make sure that you will have

sufficient time to ensure that the system is working (and have a back-up plan in case it doesn't). If you are using an overhead or slide projector, make sure that a spare bulb is available.

5. **Your appearance.** Before your presentation, check yourself in a mirror to make sure that your appearance is acceptable. Men should make sure to check the zipper on their pants. It's awkward to have someone in your audience point out that your pants need zipping. Women need to check their make-up and jewelry. Knowing that you look acceptable will help provide the additional confidence required for an effective presentation.

If you find that you are still nervous when you begin speaking (in spite of your rehearsal and Circle of Excellence), do not apologize for it or make any comment that suggests that you are inexperienced or poorly prepared. Concentrate on your message and your audience. If your throat gets dry, drink water rather than coffee or carbonated drinks, which may make your throat feel even drier.

When your time to speak arrives, walk confidently to the lectern without speaking. Create your Circle of Excellence as you approach the lectern, and then step into it, and say your code word to yourself. Plant your feet firmly, with your left foot pointed straight ahead and your right foot with your toes pointed out at a 45-degree angle. This will help you avoid the common random movements that audiences find distracting.

Before you speak, look at the audience, starting by looking at the people seated in the front on your left. Let your eyes gaze down the left side of the audience, across the back row, and then back to the front along the right side. This will pull the audience into you before you begin.

If you have been introduced, be sure to thank the person who introduced you. Express appreciation for the opportunity to speak and, perhaps, the importance of the occasion. While you speak, watch the audience for signs that everyone can hear you and follow what you are saying. Move naturally, but until you are an accomplished speaker, avoid moving and talking at the same time. Use natural pauses in your presentation to move from one location to another, plant your feet, and begin speaking again. Gesture naturally, but remember that the larger your audience, the bigger your gestures need to be for everyone to see them.

9.4. ORGANIZING THE CONTENTS

A presentation, like all communication forms, requires a specific organizational pattern to be effective, and just as letters, memos, and reports follow certain conventions formats, presentations also follow certain conventions influencing the delivery of information. These include the following:

1. Opening
2. Body
3. Closing.

Opening. The opening of a presentation is usually designed to help both the speaker and the audience feel comfortable and to orient the audience to the purpose of the presentation. The opening of a formal presentation usually establishes the tone and determines

the audience's attitude toward the speaker and the material. The following are typical openings:

1. **A joke.** When they are relevant and told well, jokes can be effective ice breakers. Audiences have been conditioned to expect a joke or two at the beginning of most presentations, so telling an appropriate joke will meet that expectation.
2. **A story.** Human interest stories are another common way of opening a presentation. People enjoy listening to stories if they make an appropriate point.
3. **Background information.** On some occasions you will need to provide some background information to orient your audience to the subject of your presentation. Remember that introductory material and explanations are not especially interesting, so interweave the required background information with something that will be of greater interest to your audience, such as a preview or a benefit.
4. **A preview.** For most presentations, a preview helps orient the audience to the basic structure of the message. A preview provides the audience with the structure of your presentation by identifying the main points and the order in which you will present them.
5. **A benefit.** Tell the members of your audience how they will benefit from your presentation. Explain what they will learn and how they will be able to use that knowledge.
6. **A special goodwill statement.** If you haven't already done so when thanking the person who introduced you, you can open by expressing appreciation for being invited to speak and referring to the importance of the occasion.

Body. The body of the presentation consists of the facts, figures, and principles you wish to convey. Because your organizational pattern must be clear to your audience, use explicit transitions from one point to the next. Tell the audience how each part contributes to the whole, and how the whole is equal to the sum of its parts. Refer to your purpose from time to time. Show how what you have already said and what you are about to say contribute to your overall purpose.

Transitions that appear artificial in written messages are beneficial in oral presentations: "Now that we have seen how X influences Y, let's briefly consider how X influences Z."

Whenever you have resistance to overcome, or when you wish to persuade an audience to change opinions or behavior, build your case slowly and carefully. If there are two sides to a subject, present both of them. Your audience will become aware of the other opinion sooner or later anyway, and if you neglect to mention the other side, they will hold that against you.

In an oral presentation, some redundancy is essential. Repeat important points. An oral message is not the same as a written message in this regard. Because your audience cannot "look back" to see what you said before, you will need to repeat important points to help them remember. Work your repetitions in naturally, however, so that the audience will not feel as though you are talking down to them.

Closing. Because it is a natural point of emphasis and because it is the last impression your audience will have of you, the closing of your presentation deserves special attention.

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End with a bang rather than a whimper, a flourish rather than a fadeout.

1. **Avoid quitting before you are finished.** Continue to speak clearly, distinctly, and forcefully throughout your entire message. Guard against allowing your voice to fade.
2. **Invite questions.** If appropriate, allow time at the end of your presentation to answer questions from the audience. If there is none, provide a brief summary before concluding.
3. **Summarize key points.** Review the main points for your audience. Emphasize the benefits associated with doing as you have suggested, or explain why knowing the information you have presented will be useful.
4. **Be specific about desired actions.** If you want your audience to act, ask specifically for that action. Explain exactly what you want your audience to do, and make the action seem easy. If appropriate, get some kind of immediate commitment from them—signing a petition, leaving names and phone numbers (or email addresses), or showing hands to indicate willingness to act.
5. **Be positive and forward-looking.** If you end your presentation on a negative note, your audience will associate you with that negative element rather than with the positive elements that may have preceded it. No matter how gloomy your topic happens to be, find some hope for the future and focus on it as you conclude your presentation.
6. **Conclude when you say you will.** If you have been allotted a specific time for your presentation, finish on time. Once you have said “In conclusion”, be sure that you conclude—restate your main point, specify an action, and quit.

9.5. THE NUANCES/MODES/DELIVERY

Having something to say is not enough; you must also know how to say it. Most audiences prefer delivery that combines a certain degree of formality with the best attributes of good conversation—directness, spontaneity, animation, vocal and facial expressiveness, and a lively sense of communication.

There are four modes of delivery, which can be used for making presentations:

1. **Extemporaneous.** Extemporaneous presentation is the most popular and effective method. Here rehearsal of presentation to be made is must but cramming must be avoided. It also requires meticulously and well organized content so as to make the presentation more effective.

Advantages

- (a) This gives enough time to prepare the presentation, so work hard on the theme/central idea to present the theme in the best structured way.
- (b) Extemporaneous gives chance to decide the outline of language to be used according to the targeted audience
- (c) The speaker can incorporate appropriate quotations, proverbs, illustrations, and statistics to make his statements authentic.

- (d) Here presentation sounds natural and spontaneous, so that the speaker can establish rapport with the audience through eye contact.
- (e) It enables one to move freely with ease.

Disadvantages

- (a) If the preparation is inadequate, the speaker can get lost and find himself uncomfortable.
- (b) If the speaker takes the support of notes or the cards prepared by him, he would lose the spontaneity of flow of ideas

2. **Manuscript.** In manuscript presentation, the material is written and the speaker is supposed to read it ad verbum. You should be wise enough not to attempt to read a speech until you have become proficient reader. Unfortunately most speakers are not good readers. They make it uninteresting by reading in a dull and monotonous way.

For effective use of this mode, you should have gone through the material several times beforehand till you become absolutely familiar with the text. You should know what is written where.

Advantages

- (a) It is a permanent and accurate record of whatever you have to say.
- (b) There is no chance of tampering with the facts and figures.
- (c) The content can be systematically organized.
- (d) Language gets polished.

Disadvantages

- (a) Since the speaker is reading from the script, he would not be able to maintain eye contact.
- (b) Non verbal communication would have less scope.
- (c) Flexibility and adoption is difficult.
- (d) In the absence of effective reading skill, you fumble over words, lose your pace, and miss punctuation marks, etc. This adds up to an uninteresting speech and loss of audience attention.

3. **Impromptu.** The impromptu mode, as the word suggests, is what you use when you have to deliver an informal speech without preparation. For example, at a formal dinner party you may be invited to deliver a vote of thanks. Don't panic and babble something in an unmethodical way. Instead, calmly state your topic and then preview the points you are to make. Be as brief as possible during your impromptu presentations.

Advantages

- (a) The speaker should be natural as he does not get enough time to make any elaborate preparation.

- (b) Speaker gets the chance to express his thoughts irrespective of what other think or say.

Disadvantages

- (a) The presentation lacks organized development of ideas because of the shortage of time.
- (b) There is no supplementary material to substantiate the speech.
- (c) The presentation may turn out to be a failure if you have inadequate proficiency in the language to use.

Keep in mind that gaining a reputation for being a good impromptu speaker can do a great deal for your career aspirations.

4. Memorization. This method of presentation is very difficult for most of us. Probably a handful of you can actually memorize an entire speech. This type of delivery stands somewhere between extemporaneous and manuscript presentation.

Advantages

- (a) It is easy for speaker to maintain eye contact with audience.
- (b) The speaker can easily move and make use of appropriate non verbal communication.
- (c) Speech can be completed in time.

Disadvantages

- (a) Memorization requires too much of time.
- (b) There are chances of making dull presentation.
- (c) Flexibility cannot be adopted during the presentation.
- (d) The speaker gets flustered if he forgets a word, sentence, or a whole paragraph.

9.6. VOICE AND BODY LANGUAGE INEFFECTIVE PRESENTATION (KINESICS)

Kinesics is the name given to the study of the body's physical movements. Nodding your head, blinking your eyes, shrugging shoulders, waving the hands, and other such physical activities are all forms of communication. Some kinesic behaviors are deliberately intended to communicate, as when your head for acceptance. Understanding non-verbal cues will develop your ability to use them more effectively during your presentations.

In face to face communication the message is conveyed on two levels simultaneously. One is verbal and other is non verbal. **It is said by Socrates** "Nobility and dignity; self-abasement and servility, insolence and vulgarity, are reflected in the face and in the attitudes of the body whether still or in motion". Non verbal communication is instinctive.

Non verbal communication is concerned with body movements (Kinesics), space (Proxemics) and vocal features (paralinguistic features). It is important that we know more about these features of body language because the verbal components of oral communication carry less than 35% of the social meaning of the situation, while more than 65% is carried on the non-verbal band. People react strongly on what they see.

Kinesics includes:

Personal Appearance. Personal appearance plays an important role; people see you before they hear you. As you adapt your language to an audience, you should also dress appositely. Appearance includes clothes, hair, jewellery, cosmetics, and so on. In today's society the purpose of clothing has altered from fulfilling a basic need to expressing oneself. Clothes accent the body's movements.

Posture. Posture generally refers to the way we hold ourselves when we stand, sit or walk. The way you sit, stand, or walk reveals a lot about you. New speakers are unsure of what to do with their body. Certain mannerisms creep in, usually from nervousness - pacing constantly, bobbing the shoulders, fidgeting with notes, jingling coins, either constantly moving or remaining static. Truly, what one speaks is very important but you do just before you begin and after you have finished is equally important.

Gesture. Gesture is the movement made by hands, arms, shoulders, head and torso. Adroit gestures can add to the impact of speech. Gestures clarify your ideas or reinforce them and should be well suited to the audience and occasion. It has been observed that there are as many as 7,00,000 varied hand gestures alone and the meanings derived from them may vary from individual to individual.

Gestures should not divert the attention of the listener and distract from your message. Speakers' gestures should be quite natural and spontaneous.

Facial Expression. Facial expressions also play an important role in presenting. The face is the most expressive part of our body. A smile stands for friendliness, a frown for discontent, raised eyebrows for disbelief, tightened jaw muscles for antagonism, etc. The face rarely sends a single message at a time. Instead it sends a series of messages-your facial expressions may show anxiety, recognition, hesitation, and pleasure in quick succession.

Eye Contact. The eyes are considered to be the windows of the soul. You look into the eyes of a speaker to help find out the truthfulness of his speech, his intelligence, attitudes, and feelings. Eye contact is a direct and powerful form of non-verbal communication. Looking directly at listeners builds rapport. Prolonging the eye contact for three to five seconds tells the audience that you are sincere in what you say and that you want them to pay attention.

PROXEMICS

Proxemics is the study of physical space in interpersonal relations. The way people use space tells you a lot about them. In a professional setting, space is used to signal power and status. Your gestures should be in accordance with the space available.

Edward T Hall is his "The Hidden Dimension" divides space into four distinct zones.

1. **Intimate.** This zone starts with personal touch and extends just to 18 inches. Members of the family, relatives etc fall under this zone. The best relationship that describes it is the mother-child relationship.
2. **Personal.** This zone stretches from 18 inches to 4 feet. Your close friends, colleagues, peers etc fall in this group. It permits spontaneous and unprogrammed communications.

3. **Social.** Social events take place in this radius of 4 feet to 12 feet. In this layer, relationships are more official. People are more cautious in their movements. You should be smart enough to conduct it with less emotion and more planning.
4. **Public.** This zone starts from 12 feet and may extend to 30 feet or to the range of eyesight and hearing. Events that take place in this zone are formal. The audience is free to do whatever it feels like.

PARALINGUISTICS

Paralinguistic features are non-verbal cues that help you to give urgency to your voice. Your voice is your trademark. Therefore, it is useful to understand the characteristic nuances of voice.

1. **Quality.** Each one of us has a unique voice and its quality depends upon its resonating mechanism. It may be rich and resonant, soft and alluring, thin and nasal, hoarse and husky, or harsh and irritating. So one can make conscious efforts to improve one's quality of voice.
2. **Volume.** Volume is the loudness or the softness of the voice. Your voice should always project but need not always be loud. You should vary your volume so as to make your voice audible and clear.
3. **Pace/Rate.** Rate is the number of words which you speak per minute. It varies from person to person and from 80 to 250 words per minute. The normal rate is from 120 to 150 words. Cultivate your pace so as to fit in this reasonable limit. Use pauses to create emphasis. A well paced, varied message suggests enthusiasm, self-assurance and awareness of audience.
4. **Pitch.** Pitch refers to the number of vibrations per second of your voice. The rise and fall of the voice convey various emotions. A well balanced pitch results in a clear and effective tone.
5. **Articulation.** Speakers should be careful not to slop, slur, chop, truncate, or omit sounds between words or sentences. If all the sounds are not uttered properly, the flow of understanding gets interrupted and deters the listener from grasping the meaning of the message. Develop in yourself the ability to speak distinctly; produce the sounds in a crisp and lucid manner.
6. **Pronunciation.** If articulation means speaking out all the sounds distinctly, then pronunciation requires us to speak out sounds in way that is generally accepted. The best way is to follow British Received pronunciation. One should be careful enough to pronounce individual sounds along with word stress, according to the set norms. Wherever there is confusion, always consult a good dictionary and try to pronounce it correctly.
7. **Voice Modulation.** Modulation refers to the way we regulate, vary or adjust the tone, pitch, and volume of the sound or speaking voice. Modulation of voice brings flexibility and vitality to your voice, and you can express emotions and sentiments in the best possible way.

8. Pauses. A pause is a short silence flanked by the words. A pause in speaking lets the listener reflect on the message and digest it accordingly. It helps you glide from one thought to another one. It embellishes your speech because it is a natural process to give a break.

9.7. TIME DIMENSION (CHRONEMICS)

Chronemics is the study of how human beings communicate through their use of time. We attempt to control time, trying to use it more effectively. Good timing is very crucial, and you should rehearse a formal presentation until it is a little under time, because staying within time limits is a mark of courtesy and professionalism.

9.7.1. INFERENCE/CONCLUSION

To recapitulate, oral presentation is an art that requires careful planning, preparation, and a great deal of practice. The tool is both valuable and relevant. Apart from communicating the main purpose of your presentation, there are various factors that you need to blend inextricably to convey your message clearly. These features are: audience analysis, organization of matter, preparation of an outline, nuances of delivery, kinesics and paralinguistics, and visual aids. Your aim should be to keep all these threads intact, neither too loose nor too tight. With care and practice, you can achieve wonders with your oral presentations.

Presentations – Step by Step :

This is the basic sequence of actions for creating and preparing a presentation up to the point of actually delivering the presentation to an audience:

1. Define the purpose.
2. Gather content and presentation ideas.
3. Structure the subject matter (sections, headings, order).
4. Develop how to present it (style, elements, props, equipment).
5. Prepare presentation (wording, design, materials, equipment).
6. Practice and rehearsals (get feedback, refinement).
7. Plan venue, control the environment.
8. 'Dress rehearsal' if warranted.
9. Relax and prepare yourself — confidence and control.

Prepare the Presentation

Consider:

1. What's the purpose?
2. For whom?
3. What outcomes and reactions are you seeking?

Consider the more detailed nature of:

1. Subject and content, audience needs, type of presentation, equipment and venue.

2. Create and gather ideas - brainstorm, mind-map, initially random, be innovative and daring.
3. Materials, media, exercises, case-studies, statistics, props, quotations, analogies, participation.
4. Anticipate questions, know your subject and reference points
5. Decide your notes system - cue cards, sheet notes.

Design the presentation

1. Plan the structure - sections, order, headings, intro/middle/close.
2. Tell'em what you're gonna tell'em, tell'em, tell'em what you told'em.
3. Use the 'rule of three'
4. Points of interest ('spice') and activities - early impact - create a credible impression.
5. Consider audience attention span and audience profile to get the language and tone right
6. Build the presentation, prepare equipment, prepare materials and props, create your prompts or notes.
7. Dry-run practise, timings, fall-backs/contingencies.
8. Practise full presentation ('dress rehearsal'), get feedback, refine, practise and practise. Practise gives you control. Control gives you confidence. Confidence and control overcome fear.

Deliver your presentation

1. Relax.
 2. If necessary revisit your notes about how to relax yourself. Stress can be managed, and to a small degree it is part of the presentation experience. Butterflies are exciting and beautiful, even if they are not in perfect formation.
 3. You have prepared and practised, so your presentation will succeed and be enjoyable.
 4. Smile.
 5. The audience is on your side.
 6. Use a solid well-rehearsed opening, make immediate friendly impact.
 7. "Tell'em what you're gonna tell'em, tell'em, then tell'em what you told'em."
 8. Use confident body-language, control, firmness, confidence, speak your audience's language, accentuate the positive (be positive and upbeat).
 9. Pause when you need to and don't apologise for it - pausing is perfectly okay.
- Use audience participation where possible, be clear, calm, close powerfully and simply and gratefully, and have fun

A BRIEF ABOUT SALES PRESENTATIONS

In business life, one has to make a presentation for selling a product or a service before various types of audiences - distributors, the press, family customers gathered in a showroom.

The sales presentation may be accompanied by a live demo, a test ride or a film clip. We recall here the sales formula of AIDA - attention, interest, desire action.

It is not always that you have an audience ready and waiting for you to deliver your talk. You may have to, like the roadside seller, gather an audience using your magnetism. Hence a sales presentation requires the best of persuasive skill.

For making a good sales presentation, the following may be remembered:

1. **Study the product technically.** If you are merchandising a surgical instrument, you may have to learn a good deal about surgery even if it is not your specialisation.
2. **Competitors.** You have to study the competitors' products.
3. **Consumer benefit.** You have to point out what gap in the consumer's life the product can fill. Cold drinks, chocolates, etc. tend to create a need.

A life that was getting along well without these foods suddenly looks incomplete after the product is presented interestingly.

You have to point out how the product can enrich a life that was seemingly content with itself. People were used to paper currency, but then cheques came in, then plastic money, and now internet transfers.

4. **Reliability.** The product should be presented as reliable. It is often the most wanted quality in a product. Hence the frequent use of the word money-back guarantee, ISI (now BIS - Bureau of Indian Standards) or ISO 9001: 2000 certification, hallmark etc.
5. **Easy to use.** The product should be presented as easy to use. A live demo or the instructions manual should convince the consumer of this.
6. **Easy to buy and maintain.** It should be presented as easy to acquire and easy to maintain. You find phrases like, "We have 3000 outlets, and surely there is one close to you," or, "We have a servicing network of 20 garages in your town," or, "In case of any difficulty, ring us toll free on xxx."
7. **Protect consumer ego.** A good sales talk avoids hurting the audience's opinions and biases. It avoids showing the consumer as a fool. We have often heard the saying, "You may win an argument but lose a friend." Instead, "The customer is always right" approach pays better.
8. **Simple language.** The language of a sales presentation needs to be simple and as far as possible non-technical. If it is technical, it is educative so. "This is a carburetor, which does the function of lungs."

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9. **Avoid humour.** Jokes are not necessary in a sales talk and in general they are rarely used. But a figurative twist to the language can be used to make the consumer smile. On driving safety, "Better be late, Mr. Singh than be Late Mr. Singh."
10. **Eye contact.** When using visual aids for a sales pitch, you should as far as possible look at the audience and not the exhibit or screen. You should not stand in the way of the visual aid. The light and visibility should be good enough for all viewers to see the visual aid clearly.
11. **Offer a trial.** It is often effective to ask one of the members of the audience to try your product.
12. **Collect orders on the spot.** You should be ready for making spot sales or getting commitments after the presentation. If it has been a good presentation, you should not allow the effect to wear off with time and distance, competitors or distractions).

9.7.2. Do's and Don'ts

Here are some simple tips to help you focus your efforts!

Do:

1. Check what is expected of you when invited to speak.
2. Prepare in plenty of time.
3. Establish a clear structure.
4. Prepare good, summarised notes.
5. Realise and accept that all good speakers experience nervous tension before speaking
6. Plan and rehearse the start with care.
7. Put pace and enthusiasm into your delivery.
8. Ensure you are clearly audible to everyone.
9. Maintain good, evenly distributed eye contact with your audience.
10. Plan and rehearse the conclusion with care.

Don't:

1. Prepare too much material; check your timing.
2. Try to do without speaker's notes.
3. Read the script verbatim.
4. Start with an apology.
5. Risk weak or dodgy jokes.
6. Split your audience's attention by misuse of aids or handouts.
7. Rock, sway or use repetitive gestures.

8. Clutter your visual aids.
9. Grable or rush.
10. Assume hostility.

Case study

Successful presentations are understandable, memorable, and emotional.

Understandable. Successful presentations are free of jargon, buzzwords, complexity, and confusion. Although there are many ways to make a presentation clear and understandable, my favorite technique is what I call the “Twitter-friendly headline.” I learned this from studying Steve Jobs and other inspiring communicators. In 2001 the iPod was “1,000 songs in your pocket.” In 2008 the MacBook Air was “The world’s thinnest notebook.” Steve Jobs always described his products in one sentence. Even before Twitter existed, Jobs’ product descriptions never exceeded 140 characters.

The other day I spoke to bestselling author Daniel Pink about his new book, *To Sell is Human*. Pink is skilled at public speaking and had years of experience as a political speechwriter before he wrote books. When he prepares for a presentation he asks himself, “What’s the one big idea I want people to take away from my presentation?” If you’re pitching a product, what’s the one thing you want your customers or investors to know about it? If you can express it in 140 characters or less, you’ll help your audience make sense of your product and how it will benefit their lives.

Memorable. If your audience cannot remember what you said in your presentation or recall your idea, it doesn’t matter how great it is! Again, there are many techniques to communicate ideas in memorable ways, but my favorite is a concept I’ve discussed in an earlier column—the rule of three. Neuroscientists generally agree that the human mind can only consume anywhere from three to seven points in short term, or “working memory” (This is why the phone number is only seven digits. Long ago scientists discovered if you ask people to remember eight digits, they forget just about the entire sequence of numbers). The magic number—not too many and not too few—seems to be three.

Try to incorporate the rule of three in your presentations. You can divide your presentation into three parts, discuss “three benefits” of a product, or give your audience “three action steps” they can take. Packaging the content into groups of three makes it far easier to remember.

Emotional. There’s a large body of research that shows the emotional component of a message trumps the analytical. Yes, you need to show data and evidence to reinforce your position, but it’s the emotional part of a presentation that often moves people to action.

Storytelling is the easiest and most effective way to make your presentation emotional. I once interviewed a prominent attorney who won the largest punitive judgment against a pharmaceutical company at the time—\$250 million. He showed me the slides he used in his opening argument. The first six slides told a story and showed pictures of the person who lost his life. When the trial was over he asked the jurors why they voted the way they did. It seems the drug company lawyers had called to the stand scientists who confused the jurors with mountains of data and statistics. The jurors, however, were more moved by the simple story that opened the trial. They specifically mentioned the story as one of the reasons behind their

decision. Stories are powerful, under-appreciated, and rarely used. If you want to stand out, tell more of them.

Poor communication and presentation skills can sink your brand and your career. I see it happen all the time. I've also seen way too many great ideas go undiscovered because the people who have those ideas fail to communicate effectively. We need big ideas to solve big problems, and we need inspiring leaders who can present those ideas so they are understandable, memorable, and make an emotional connection with their audiences.

EXERCISE

1. To participate effectively in an effective presentation one requires the right combination of speaking abilities and strategies explain.
2. What is the need of audience analysis before a presentation?
3. Comment on body language as a presentation strategy.
4. Often it is difficult to know where to begin. When you are preparing a presentation what do you think is the first thing you should consider? Why?
5. What are the points you keep in mind while giving an oral presentation?
6. What is proxemics? What is its use in presentation strategies? Elucidate.
7. In your opinion, what is the best format for making a presentation.
8. What are the key elements required for developing good public speaking skills?
9. What are the key elements required for developing good public speaking skills?
10. How important are paralinguistic features in face to face communication?
11. As a speaker how would you plan for the key note address in the founder's day celebrations of a company?
12. What are the parameter do you pay attention in developing the public speaking skills.
13. Use of visual aids help to make presentations elaborative explain.
14. Kinesics proxemics and chronemics play vital roles in presentation elaborate.
15. What is stage fright? What courses it ? How can it be overcome?

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